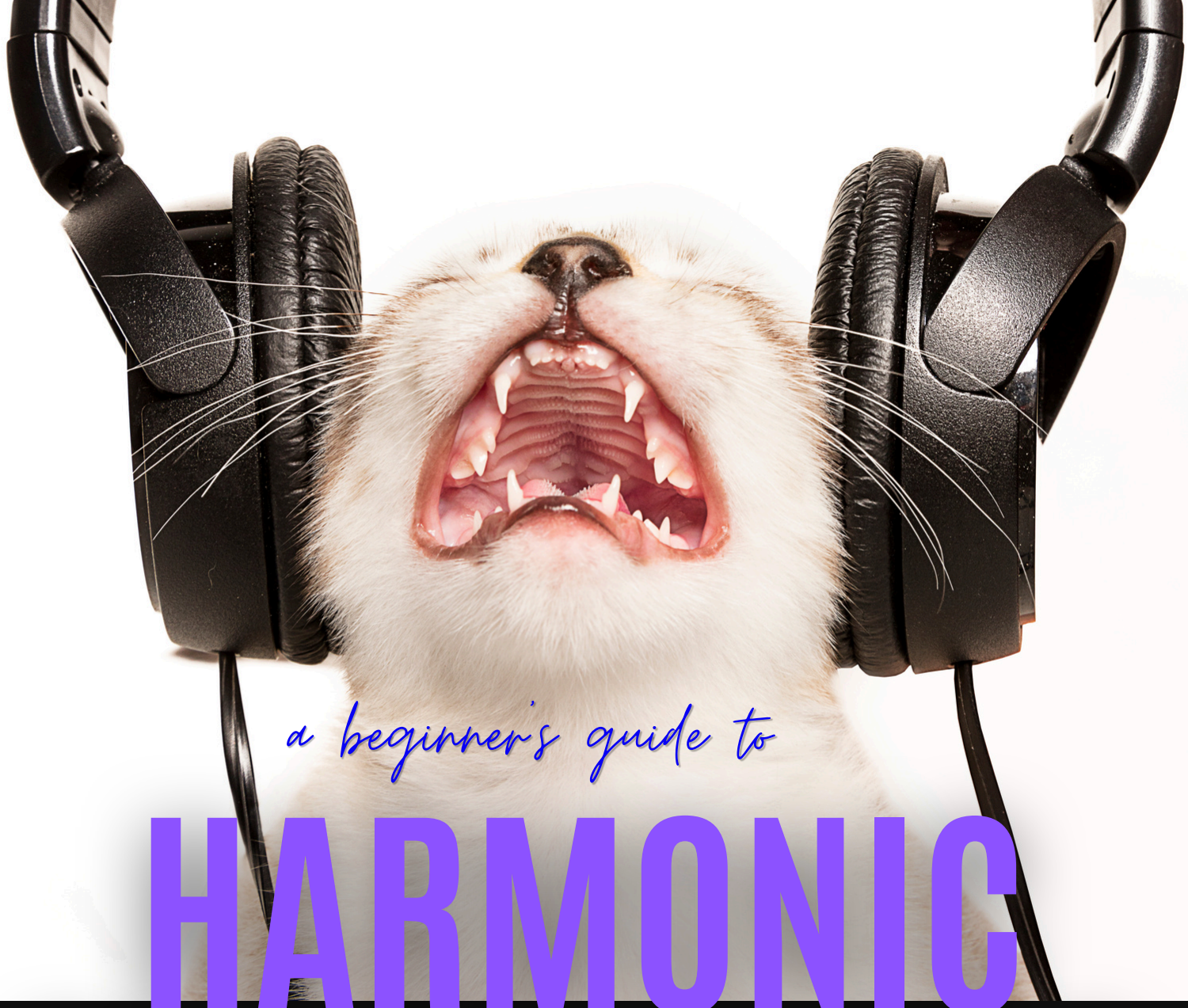


a beginner's guide to

HARMONIC EAR TRAINING

LEVEL 1

Embark on a Journey of Musical Discovery with Henrique Eisenmann & Tim Lienhard. Explore More from Jazz Lab Music – youtube.com/@jazzlabmusic or jazzlabmusic.org.

JAZZ LAB

INTRO

EAR TRAINING



Melodic ear training tends to receive most of the attention, yet the ability to understand and recognize chords is just as—if not more—essential for today's improviser. It accelerates memorization, deepens fluency in improvisation, and makes learning new repertoire significantly more efficient. Still, many students feel stuck when it comes to hearing chords and progressions, often lacking both the confidence and the tools to engage with them. Part of the problem is that high-quality resources in this area remain surprisingly scarce.

CHALLENGES



Here is why harmonic ear training is hard:

1. Listening to bass notes is hard for those who are not bassists. Most ears gravitate towards melody. Also, many of our voices are unable to match such lower pitches, so we must get used to octave equivalents.

2. lack of piano skills. Yes, we all have to play some basic piano in order to hear progressions (guitar is also good, although we recommend piano). This may be frustrating to hear but WE ARE ONLY CAPABLE OF HEARING THE THINGS WE ARE CAPABLE OF PLAYING. If you have never played a specific chord or progression, it's unlikely that you will recognize it. If you wanna transcribe Herbie Hancock's chords, you have got to be able play them with ease.



HERE'S HOW TO GET BETTER

1. Understanding basics of harmonic analysis (simple diatonic chords, simple secondary dominants, then some modal interchanges)

2. Learning to hear and sing back bass notes and the intervals it forms.

3. Getting used to the “ethos” (the emotional character that each chord carries) and how progressions follow an emotional narrative.

4. Memorizing entire progressions instead of individual chords. Composing a different short piece of music for each new progression you learn.

BASICS OF HARMONIC ANALYSIS:

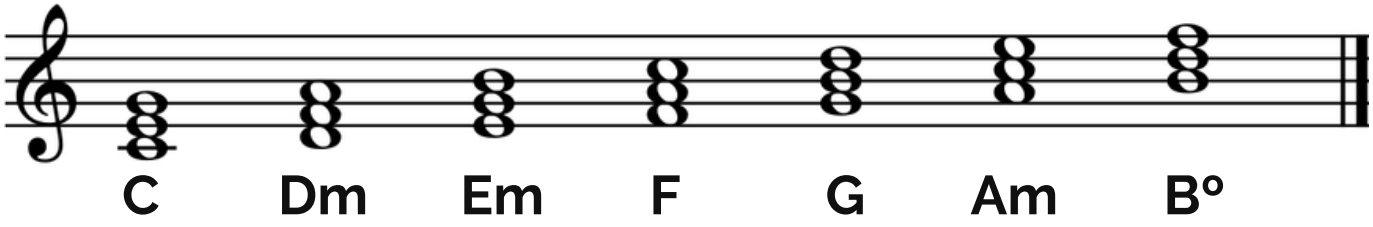
the chord family



DIATONIC CHORDS

Diatonic chords are all the possible chords you can create by stacking thirds using exclusively the notes of a given scale. I like calling this a "chord family", since the resulting chords function as a family, they often relate to one another, and most songs only utilize chords from the same family. Experiment playing them on the piano.

C major chord Family



these chords also receive the following names:

I ii iii IV V vi vii°

THE FOUR CHORD POP-PROGRESSIONS



If you have never seen this, stop everything and search on Youtube for "Axis of Awesome - 4 chord songs"

There are two 4-chord progressions that have spread deeply into the universe of pop music, becoming a formula for catchy songs. This is an excellent starting point to start memorizing progressions. You should become a master in identifying these two progressions:

C	Am	F	G
I	vi	IV	V

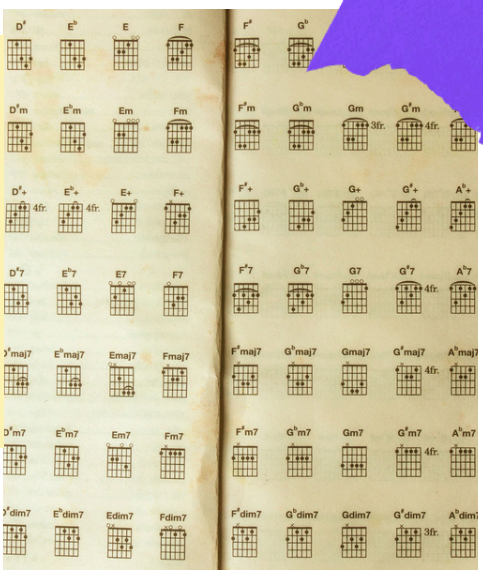
AND

Am	F	C	G
vi	IV	I	V

Start by singing the bass notes of both these progressions. Remember that often the bass note of the I chord (also known as Tonic) may be sung/played an octave higher. Memorize the melody these bass notes create.

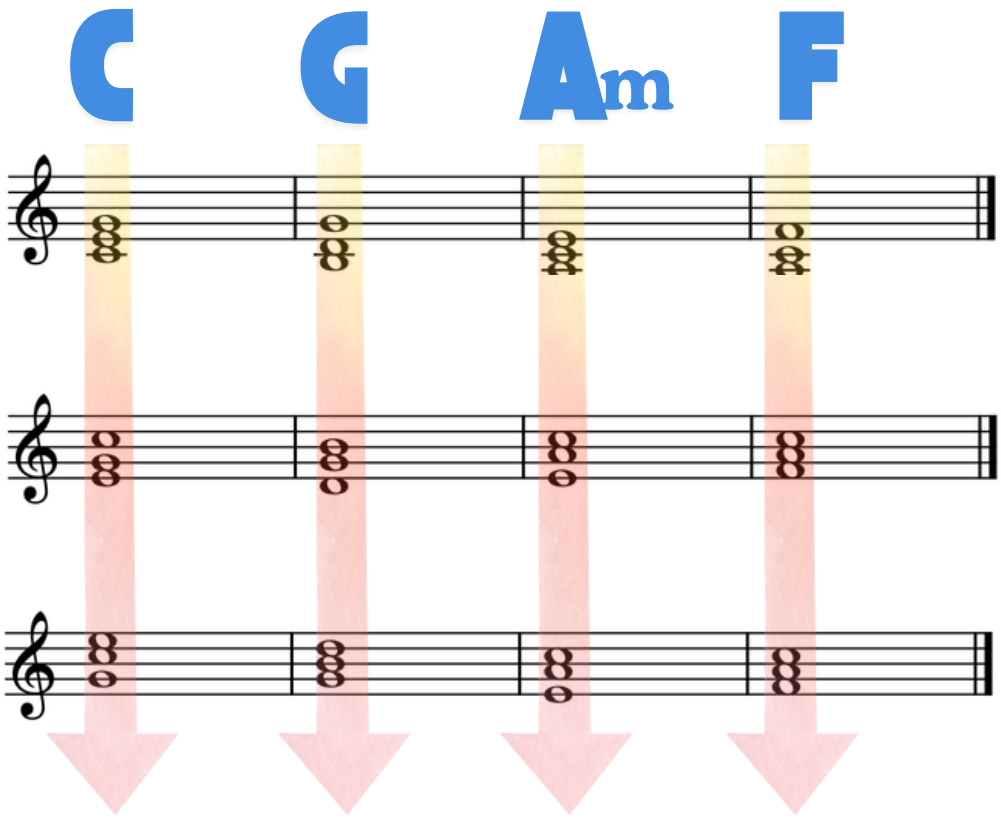


PRACTICE DIFFERENT INVERSIONS

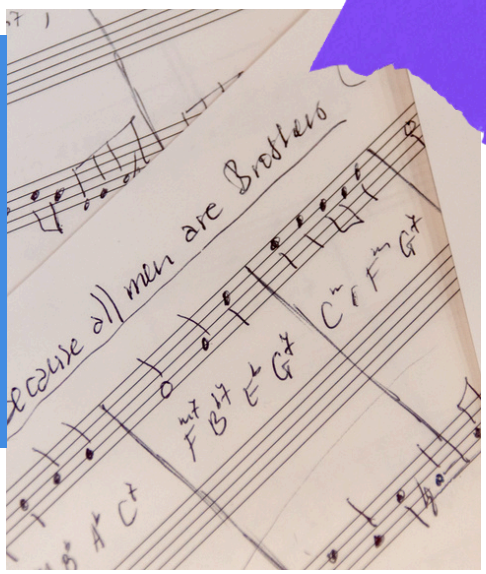


Once you memorize those two basslines, practice playing those chords on a piano. However, try using inversions (when needed), to preserve as many common tones as possible. Your left hand can continue to play the original roots of the chords - the inversions are only for your right hand.

Using the I-V-vi-IV as an example, here are three possibilities



APPLY ALL THIS TO REAL PIECES



Let's look at list of songs that feature these progressions. You can find an even larger list on the wikipedia page of I-V-vi-IV progression.

- "Otherside" (Red Hot Chilli Peppers)
- "One last Breath" (Creed)
- "Let it Be" (Beatles)
- "California King Bed" (Rihanna)
- "If I were a Boy" (Beyonce)
- "Girls like You" (Maroon 5)
- "Self Esteem" (The Offspring)
- "You are Beautiful" (James Blunt)
- "Where is the Love" (Black Eyed Peas)
- "I'm Yours" (Jason Mraz)

All of these are very known pop/rock songs. Even if you want to hear more sophisticated progressions, you should still start from these simple examples.

If you don't have a lot of piano experience, I recommend using the transpose function, so that you will always play in the key of C major.

LISTEN to the songs above. Try **SINGING** and matching the bass notes. **IDENTIFY** the progression. **PLAY** together on the piano.

C G Am F

Am F C G

THE ETHOS of CHORDS



Another incredibly important way to recognize chord progressions is to understand that every different chord of a chord family has a specific emotional affect (an "ethos"); a dramatic character. Many musicians use these emotions as a way to identify chords. This also helps us understand why certain progressions are so effective. It's not necessarily about the intervals, it's about the emotional narrative they create. In music theory, this is an area connected to Functional Harmony.

C **The I Chord**
Ethos: heroic, joyful, home, safety, comfort.



F **The IV Chord**
Ethos: loving, hopeful, tender, spiritual.



Am **The vi Chord**
Ethos: evil, sad, depressed, antagonist.



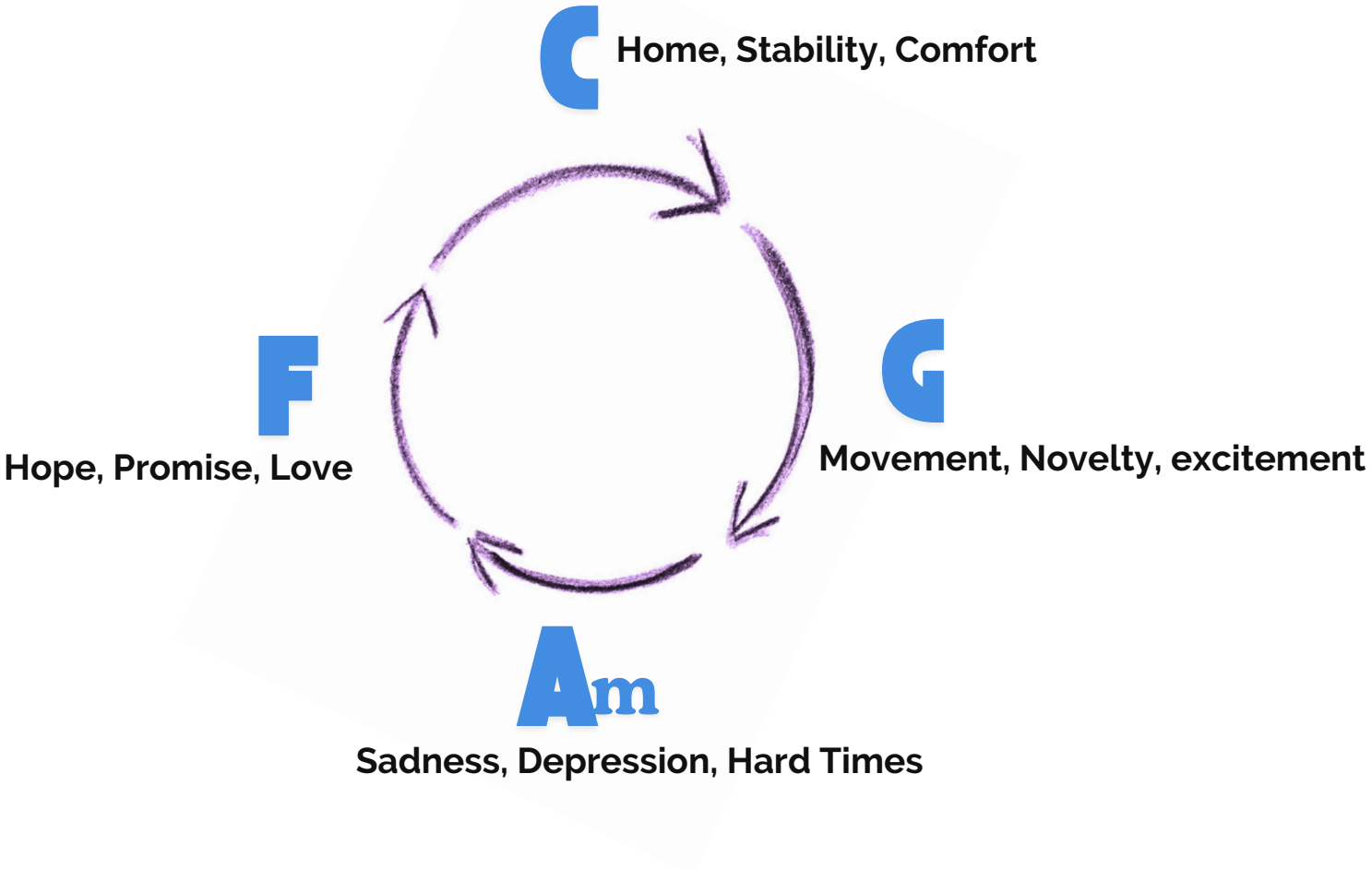
G **The V Chord**
Ethos: best friend, excited, joyful, adventurous.



THE ETHOS of CHORDS



Once you understand the emotional character of each chord, it becomes clear why these common chord progressions are so catchy. They are basically a vicious cycle, an emotional roller coaster that offers you tension and then hope and relief. This cycle is pretty addictive, hence the popularity of these chord progressions.





PRACTICE SUGGESTIONS

- Compose a piece using each of these chord progressions.
- Try identifying the progressions without the help of a piano.
- Try recognizing whether there are any inversions on the bass notes (For example, the V chord is often played with a 3rd on the bass).
- Experiment creating your own unique progression and identifying what is the emotional narrative it tells.
- Search on your streaming platform for playlists of 4 chord songs to practice.
- Experiment improvising over these chords. What types of scales or notes work over these chords?
- Try singing an arpeggio of each individual chord (see page 7), similar to the exercise we played on the piano, but this time singing each note.

NEXT



DON'T MISS OUR NEXT CHAPTER

- Using the ii and iii chords
- Memorizing the Romanesca progression
- Hearing Secondary Dominants
- Minor progressions
- Modal interchanges
- Recognizing different ii-V-I
- Recognizing tensions and upper structures.